There was a considerable contrast between the two sisters. Rucha was very protective of her younger sister. She was overprotective with her. Rucha herself had been overprotected. She seldom did things rashly. Even in running and playing, she would be conscious of her movements. Seema, on the other hand, was bold and prone to taking risks.

Next week, inter-house badminton matches were to be held in the school. Rucha was in the senior team. She gave up other activities and practised with her friends. "Rucha, hit harder," they told her on the day of the match.

Aruna, a very good player of their house, was expected to win. And she did. Rucha and her opponent were almost evenly matched and Rucha lost the game by a couple of points.

Their house stood second in the overall tally. "I can't seem to win," said Rucha remorsefully. "You played all right," Aruna consoled her. "The time when your opponent was at the net, if you had hit just a little harder over her head, you could have won that point."

"I know, I know," replied Rucha, "but somehow I always make such mistakes."

"You must practice more. That is all," Aruna told her.

"I suppose so," Rucha replied gloomily.

"Cheer up now," Aruna told her. "At least you tried. I say, the inter-school sports meet is coming up. You are in the school's relay team, aren't you?"

"I will probably make everyone lose the race," Rucha said, still gloomy.

"Don't think that way," Aruna pleaded with her. "You run fast. We need you."

Rucha finally agreed to stand in if no better person could be found. Meanwhile, she would train with the rest of them under the new PT instructor, Prakash Sir.

He was very enthusiastic about sports and drove the children hard—praising, scolding, correcting but mostly encouraging them.

"Rucha, you are nimble and light. You can do better than that," he told her often.

"How can I do that?" Rucha confided to Aruna. "I will most probably fall."

"Don't be silly. We are all trying to better ourselves. You must try too," Aruna told her.

"Springfields have a very FAST RUNNER in their team." Shabnam, their teammate informed them. "Has anyone heard about her? It seems they call her P.T. Usha!"

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